The Early Dynasties

After Octavian defeated the forces of Queen Cleopatra VII of Egypt and her husband Mark Anthony at the Battle of Actium in 31 BCE, he declared himself the first emperor of Rome and became known as Augustus Caesar. His uncle was Julius Caesar, the former husband of Cleopatra. He is often regarded as the first emperor but Julius Caesar never took the title and instead chose to take the title of a dictator. After Julius Caesar, the Senate granted Octavian the title of Emperor as a reward for annihilating strong enemies and bringing stability back to Rome.

Augustus ruled the Roman Empire between 31 BCE and 14 CE. He established a series of religious and social reforms that continued to influence the empire and his heirs long after his death. He created new laws, protected the borders, constructed various new buildings and secured the reputation of Rome as one of the greatest powers in the ancient world. For two centuries, Rome enjoyed the Pax Romana, which is also known as the Roman Peace. Augustus is often credited with creating a time of great harmony and prosperity in Rome.

After Augustus died in 14 CE, he was succeeded by Tiberius who carried on with many of the emperor's policies. What he did not possess was Augustus' personality and vision for Rome's future. Augustus, Tiberius, Caligula, Claudius and Nero were part of the Julio-Claudian Dynasty. Caligula has long been known for his immorality and lunacy but his early reign was quite successful. It was the same for Claudius who was able to expand Roman rule into Britannia (modern day Britain). This was something that the great Julius Caesar himself was unable to do. Nero on the other hand had issues from the start and ended up committing suicide. Caligula was killed by his guards and Claudius by his wife. Rome eventually fell into the Year of the Four Emperors after the demise of the Julio-Claudian emperors.

Over a period of one year after Nero's death in 68 CE, Galba, Otho, Vitellius and Vespasian all took the throne. Upon Galba's assuming power, it was clear that he wasn't fit to rule and the Praetorian Guard assassinated